

SEO Audit Checklist

A practical, evidence-based checklist for auditing website search visibility

Website / Business: _____	Audit date: _____
Auditor: _____	Scope / URL set: _____
Primary market: _____	Revision: _____

Purpose	A repeatable worksheet for technical SEO, on-page SEO, content quality, internal linking, structured data, performance, and measurement.
Scope	Use for a full-site audit or as a page-by-page QA worksheet. Validate claims and platform-specific requirements against current documentation before deployment.

How to use this worksheet

- [] Review every item that applies to the audited site or profile. Mark N/A only when the item genuinely does not apply.
- [] Record evidence such as URL, screenshot, HTTP response, Search Console report, Business Profile field, or test result.
- [] Fix in dependency order: access and crawlability first, then indexability and canonicalization, then page/content quality, then measurement and ongoing maintenance.

Status key	[] Pass	[] Needs work	[] N/A	[] Verified
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Primary references include Google Search Central, Search Console Help, and related official documentation. This worksheet focuses on actionable audit evidence rather than a single numerical SEO score.

01 Crawlability and access

Audit objective: Confirm search engines can discover and fetch the URLs that matter.

Robots and crawl controls

- [] Open /robots.txt and confirm it returns HTTP 200 from the canonical host.
- [] Confirm robots.txt does not accidentally block important directories, assets, CSS, JavaScript, or public page URLs.
- [] Confirm the Sitemap directive, when used, points to the canonical absolute sitemap URL.
- [] Check that crawl controls are consistent across HTTP/HTTPS and any active subdomains or ports.
- [] Do not use robots.txt as the primary method for removing a URL from the index; use the appropriate noindex or removal workflow when exclusion from search is required.

Discoverability and links

- [] Confirm every indexable page can be reached through crawlable internal links, navigation, or another reliable discovery path.
- [] Identify orphan pages that have no internal links pointing to them.
- [] Check important pages are not dependent on form submission, client-only UI, or non-crawlable event handlers for discovery.
- [] Review pagination, filters, search results, and parameter URLs for crawl waste or unintended indexation.

Sitemap

- [] Confirm the XML sitemap is valid, accessible, and contains the preferred canonical URLs that should be discovered.
- [] Remove clearly duplicate, redirecting, non-canonical, or noindex URLs from the sitemap.
- [] Submit the sitemap in Google Search Console and review parsing/indexing signals.
- [] After launches or major migrations, update the sitemap promptly and verify the deployed version.

Notes:

02 Indexability and canonicalization

Audit objective: Make sure eligible pages can be indexed and duplicate signals consistently identify the preferred URL.

HTTP and response behavior

- [] Test representative URLs and confirm expected HTTP status codes: 200 for indexable pages, 301/308 for permanent redirects, and appropriate 4xx/5xx responses for unavailable resources.
- [] Find redirect chains and loops; shorten chains where practical.
- [] Confirm custom 404 pages return an actual 404 or other deliberate response rather than a soft 200.
- [] Check HTTP-to-HTTPS and alternate-host redirects so the canonical site is consistent.

Robots directives and indexability

- [] Check each important page for accidental meta robots or X-Robots-Tag values such as noindex or nofollow.
- [] Confirm important resources required for rendering are not blocked from crawlers.
- [] For pages meant to be excluded, verify the exclusion method matches the goal and does not conflict with robots.txt or redirects.
- [] Use Search Console URL Inspection on critical URLs to compare live-page behavior with Google's indexed version.

Canonicalization

- [] Confirm each indexable page has a clear canonical strategy and that rel="canonical" values are absolute, valid URLs.

- [] Ensure the canonical points to a page that is accessible, indexable, and representative of the content.
- [] Check for conflicting signals among redirects, canonical tags, sitemap inclusion, and internal links.
- [] Inspect duplicate or near-duplicate URL clusters and verify Google's selected canonical when the issue matters.
- [] After a site move or URL change, verify redirects and canonical signals together; do not rely on one signal in isolation.

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03 On-page SEO and content

Audit objective: Ensure each page clearly communicates its purpose, topic, and value to people and search engines.

Page titles and headings

- [] Confirm every indexable page has a descriptive element.
- [] Avoid titles that are vague, duplicated across unrelated pages, or unnecessarily verbose.
- [] Confirm the primary heading reflects the page purpose and is not hidden from the DOM.
- [] Use meaningful subheadings to organize long content.

Meta descriptions and snippets

- [] Give important pages unique, page-specific meta descriptions that summarize the page accurately.
- [] Avoid keyword lists, boilerplate descriptions, and descriptions unrelated to visible page content.
- [] Do not assume the meta description is always the snippet; treat it as a useful hint for search presentation, not a guarantee.

Content quality

- [] Confirm the main content directly satisfies the page's intended search intent and user need.
- [] Remove or revise thin sections that add little original value.
- [] Verify claims, dates, pricing, service details, and other facts are current.
- [] Check that important information is present in crawlable HTML/DOM content, not only in images or inaccessible client-side elements.
- [] Review for duplicate or substantially overlapping pages that compete for the same purpose.

Keyword and language usage

- [] Use words real users would use to describe the topic, service, product, or problem addressed by the page.
- [] Place important terminology naturally in prominent page elements where useful: title, heading, body copy, alt text, and descriptive link text.
- [] Do not force repeated exact-match phrases or create location/keyword variants solely to manipulate search results.

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04 Internal linking, images, and structured data

Audit objective: Improve discovery and page understanding with clear site relationships and machine-readable information.

Internal links

- [] Link important pages from relevant, already-discovered pages.
- [] Use descriptive anchor text that helps users understand the destination.
- [] Find broken internal links, misleading anchors, and links to redirected or non-canonical URLs.

- [] Review navigation depth for high-value pages; avoid making critical content unnecessarily hard to reach.

Images and media

- [] Use sharp, relevant images near relevant text.
- [] Confirm important images have useful, descriptive alt text when the image conveys information; use empty alt text for purely decorative images when appropriate.
- [] Use descriptive filenames and context, while avoiding keyword stuffing.
- [] Compress oversized images and confirm responsive delivery does not create layout shifts or broken assets.
- [] Check that important visual information is also available as text when users and search engines need the information.

Structured data

- [] Use structured data only where the page actually contains the information represented by the markup.
- [] Choose the most specific applicable Schema.org type and follow Google Search Central feature requirements.
- [] Validate markup in the Rich Results Test when a Google rich-result feature applies.
- [] Use Search Console and URL Inspection after deployment to confirm Google can access and process the page.
- [] Monitor structured-data reports for parse errors and feature-specific issues.

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05 Performance, mobile, and security

Audit objective: Confirm the site provides a technically sound experience across common devices and connections.

Core Web Vitals

- [] Check real-user Core Web Vitals where data is available: LCP, INP, and CLS.
- [] Target LCP at or below 2.5 seconds, INP at or below 200 milliseconds, and CLS at or below 0.1 for a good experience.
- [] Investigate slow server response, render-blocking resources, oversized media, long JavaScript tasks, and layout-shifting elements.
- [] Test representative templates, not just the home page.

Responsive and mobile experience

- [] Test navigation, forms, buttons, tables, modals, and important content at common viewport widths.
- [] Confirm text and interactive targets remain usable without horizontal scrolling caused by layout errors.
- [] Check that mobile and desktop expose the same essential information and links.

Security and reliability

- [] Confirm HTTPS is used consistently and mixed-content warnings are absent.
- [] Check for broken third-party scripts, expired certificates, CDN errors, and intermittent server failures.
- [] Verify production environment settings are not exposing staging pages, debug output, test content, or temporary URLs.

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06 Search Console, analytics, and deployment QA

Audit objective: Turn the audit into a verified release process with measurable evidence.

Search Console

- [] Confirm the correct property is verified and includes the canonical production URL.
- [] Review Performance queries, pages, clicks, impressions, and click-through rate trends for the relevant date range.
- [] Use URL Inspection on priority pages after important fixes or deployments.
- [] Review indexing, sitemap, Core Web Vitals, and enhancements reports where applicable.

Analytics and event tracking

- [] Verify analytics is installed once per page/template and is not duplicated by multiple implementations.
- [] Test critical conversion events end to end, such as form submission, phone click, appointment request, or purchase.
- [] Confirm attribution parameters are preserved through redirects and form flows where needed.
- [] Document what each conversion event means and who owns the reporting.

Release verification

- [] Crawl a sample of production URLs after deployment and compare status, canonical, title, meta robots, and internal links with expected values.
- [] Open robots.txt and sitemap.xml directly from the public domain and confirm the deployed versions are correct.
- [] Test priority page URLs in URL Inspection after major launches, migrations, or indexing fixes.
- [] Verify old URLs redirect correctly after migrations and that important external/internal references have been updated.
- [] Record the release date, commit/deployment ID, tests performed, and unresolved issues.

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Audit conclusion and handoff

Use this page to convert findings into an implementation queue. Evidence should be specific enough that another person can reproduce the finding.

Priority and evidence log

Priority	Finding / evidence	Action / owner	Status
P0	Indexation / access blocker affecting important URLs		[]
P1	Canonical, redirect, template, or major technical defect		[]
P1	High-value page content or metadata issue		[]
P2	Internal linking, structured data, performance, or UX improvement		[]
P3	Monitoring, refinement, or backlog item		[]

Acceptance checklist

- [] All priority URLs were tested in production, not only in a local or staging environment.
- [] No unintended noindex, robots, redirect, canonical, or access blocks remain on priority URLs.
- [] Sitemap and robots.txt match the intended production architecture.
- [] Titles, descriptions, headings, links, and visible content were reviewed on high-value templates/pages.
- [] Structured data was validated where used and verified on representative deployed pages.
- [] Analytics and conversion events were tested end to end.
- [] Open issues have an owner, priority, evidence, and next action.

Authoritative references

Google Search Essentials: <https://developers.google.com/search/docs/essentials>
SEO Starter Guide: <https://developers.google.com/search/docs/fundamentals/seo-starter-guide>
Title links: <https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/title-link>
Sitemaps overview: <https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/sitemaps/overview>
Canonicalization: <https://developers.google.com/search/docs/crawling-indexing/canonicalization>
Local Business structured data: <https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/structured-data/local-business>
URL Inspection: <https://support.google.com/webmasters/answer/9012289>
Search Console Performance: <https://support.google.com/webmasters/answer/7576553>
Web Vitals: <https://web.dev/articles/vitals>

Note: Google can change search features, supported structured-data fields, and Business/Property tooling. Re-check the linked official documentation when conducting a current audit.